

representatives at a meeting held in the Pentagon. The language was intended for use in business and government and has a cumbersome syntax, though programs written in it are easy to modify. It was based on Grace Hopper's FLOWMATIC, which is also known as the "mother of COBOL" and also on IBM's COMTRAN. The first compiler was developed in 1961, and usage exploded. COBOL It was estimated that in 1997, 80 per cent of businesses all over the world ran on COBOL, with 180 billion lines of code in existence and five billion lines added annually. The last COBOL revision was in 2002.

August: Panasonic, which brought us VHS

Panasonic was founded as Matsushita Electric Corporation of America. It started by manufacturing audio equipment. It is a competitor of Sony and Hitachi and was locked in a fierce fight with Sony over videotape formats in the late 70s. (VHS, supported by Panasonic, ultimately pushed over the Sony-backed Betamax. VHS gave more recording time and faster rewind and fast forward rates than Betamax.) It is one of the largest manufacturers of consumer electronics. Panasonic is still called Matsushita in Japan.

October: IBM's 1400 series

IBM launched the 1400 series for business users. This series of computers was the second-generation transistorised machines, which could be operated either independently, with IBM's punch card equipment, or with other computers. The line remained in production until the early 1970s.

Compared to the present day, the '50s were anything but exciting. People wrestled with bulky radios and the ledger was the most reliable way of keeping records. But seeds of advances that dazzled the world in later years were sown in the '50s, the prime examples being the silicon chip and the IC.